

The Enigma of Arrival

Believe it or not, since 2000, India has won more Tests overseas than any other team bar Australia

■ By Sharda Ugra

A most astonishing statistic emerged from the jelly-bean hailstorm that was the Trent Bridge Test. No other team, barring Australia, has won more Test matches overseas since 2000 than India. Sixteen for the record. And stop gawping. But how did India turn from roadkill into guys Huen Tsang could hang out with? How come we didn't notice? Probably because we were busy watching trashy cricket shows on tv and listening to Kapil Dev manfully dump on Sachin Tendulkar.

Now, winning Tests everywhere you go as India have done is terrific, but that part of the evolutionary process must be considered concluded for the team. It must be series wins next. But cricket evolution is no Darwinesque progression from a lower form of being to a higher one. It can reverse itself or, as in the case of India and the BCCI, go around in circles. If you're not moving forwards, as our stern-faced leader Rahul Dravid will remind us, you're really going backwards. So, a win at the Oval is a must. Nervous travellers no more, India must now be bold adventurers.

In the post-Packer era, only the West Indies and Australia have consistently dominated both home and away. Other Test sides enjoyed passages of excellence when playing in alien conditions. Pakistan were at their most formidable in the 1990s, when they won 17 out of 41 Tests away from home and series in England, India, Sri Lanka, New Zealand and Zimbabwe.

New Zealand were competitive in the mid-'80s, winning series in

Australia, England and Sri Lanka. Under Nasser Hussain, England won series in Pakistan and Sri Lanka. South Africa, led by Hansie Cronje, beat India, Pakistan, New Zealand and Zimbabwe in their den. While other teams tussled, India withered away.

After winning three Tests outside the country in the '80s, India won a lone Test in Colombo in the 1990s. Going overseas meant going downhill. Sanjay Manjrekar, one of the more forthright from that miserable period,

in gruesome, super slow-mo detail.

In 2001, when India beat Zimbabwe to win its first Test outside the subcontinent since 1986, the then coach John Wright couldn't work out why every Indian in Bulawayo was doing cartwheels. Given that India had snapped Australia's 16-Test winning streak and beaten them in a home series, Zimbabwe should have been a sneeze. The distance between home and away for the Indians, it seemed, was not geographical but mental.

The wheel began to turn slowly and painfully when India's stellar batsmen knuckled down to bat as long as they could no matter where they were, and younger fast bowlers came through to support the veterans.

Footage of the team's first few overseas wins post-2000 featured well-known and largely well-behaved men falling on the field or racing around wild-eyed, shrieking like children. The images brought to mind the paroxysms of joy seen at an evangelist's mass healing. Perhaps that is exactly what the away victories were.

The public celebrations after Trent Bridge were more restrained because the series was not won and Johannesburg 2006 remains vivid: after its first-

ever Test win in South Africa, India went home with a 1-2 result and a bill for trashing the Joburg dressing room.

Trent Bridge has given India a new reputation it must carry well to the Oval and beyond.

India's cricketers of the new millennium have given their successors a legacy they may not even fathom: the freedom to travel light. ■

REUTERS/DARREN STAPLES



FIRING AWAY: Dravid and Ganguly (back to camera) celebrate

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once said, "As a team, we had not gone anywhere. We weren't respected away from home, but home wins would turn us into heroes again."

The difference in home and away results coincided with the explosion of the game as a money spinner and a tv staple. Not only were India's failures overseas frequent and common place, the entire nation could see them live,